

FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Last week, the 22nd India Today Conclave took place at a time when the world is changing at a dizzying pace. Every realm familiar to us is undergoing disruptions at speeds never seen before. Artificial Intelligence is transforming our lives on a real-time basis even as it itself gets transformed by the minute. Then, to top it all, Donald J. Trump's return to the White House has been like a meteor hitting the old world order. We therefore chose 'Age of Acceleration' as the theme for the Conclave. As an array of protagonists, domain specialists and thought leaders gave us a kaleidoscope of first-person perspectives on geopolitics, technology, warfare, politics, education, business, lifestyles and entertainment, it provided us with a fascinating ringside view of a world in intense motion.

Two fast-shooting frontiersmen from the Trumpian universe got us right to the action. In an exclusive live video from Washington DC, Secretary of Commerce Howard Lutnick did some plainspeaking on the hottest topic of the day: tariffs. Rejecting product-by-product tariffs in favour of a broad-based, macro shift, he said, "It is time to do something big that connects the US and India on a grand scale. PM Modi can do this because he has a great relationship with President Trump." If Lutnick was blunt, Mike Pompeo, Secretary of State and CIA director in Trump's first term, sketched an insightful picture of the President's recent actions and way of functioning. The top-billed presence on the podium, he drew from his Trump 1.0 experience to convey one message: ignore the "noise" and watch the "through-lines". Do not be misled by Trump's unpredictable turns. Instead, look at outcomes and what is done, and you'll see a coherent pattern into which all the pieces of the puzzle integrate. Putting up a staunch defence of Trump's policies, he justified America's withdrawal from multilateral institutions saying they were "broken" and dominated by the Chinese.



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AI, a realm witnessing a world war of sorts even as the technology itself transforms all domains of human activity, emerged as an all-pervading leitmotif. A gallery of frontline experts gave us illuminating ways to prepare for an AI-driven future while humanity reckons with its unknown unknowns. Eminent British computer scientist Toby Walsh parried alarmist notions of a "zombie intelligence" taking over the world and batted for making AI a democratic force for universal good rather than the monopoly of "White males in Silicon Valley, with their agendas". India, in his view, was well-placed to write its own destiny on silicon. Microsoft India president Puneet Chandok painted AI adoption as an "integral part of skilling" as it begins its "diffusion from commerce to communities, from finance to farms". Deloitte's Nitin Mittal underlined why India must build AI infrastructure to increase its "manufacturing capacity" of knowledge.

Not a niche subject like before, technology was a theme that washed over everything else at the Conclave. Nowhere did the urgency show more than in the words of India's three service chiefs. Army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi highlighted the "nearly 100 per cent" collusion between China and Pakistan on "the virtual front", even as their strategic partnership creates a landscape of threat along India's "two-and-a-half fronts". Navy chief Adm. Dinesh K. Tripathi drew two lessons for India from the Ukraine-Russia conflict: how tech adoption had changed the "character of war", and why India must reduce dependence on fickle big powers and accelerate *aatmanirbharta*. The most telling case for this came from Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh, who subtly underlined the dangerous deficit the air force faces when China is said to have raised sixth-generation fighter jets, and our indigenisation efforts lag behind.

Even if the domestic theatre seems almost static compared to geopolitics, it bristled with its own notes of dominance and conflict. Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath was the star among Indian politicians, a lineup that included Telangana CM A. Revanth Reddy, Sikkim's Prem Singh Tamang and Delhi's newly crowned BJP face Rekha Gupta. Fresh from the success of the Mahakumbh, Yogi made a case for UP's renaissance to be built on expanded religious tourism and modern economic hubs. Reddy took a dig at the BJP, calling the Gujarat model "a Test match model", in contrast to his own "T20 model". Andhra Pradesh's IT minister Nara Lokesh found ways to affirm his party's NDA fraternity, skilfully navigating past the South's concerns over delimitation and Hindi.

Aamir Khan, one week shy of 60 on the day, was the graceful marquee presence from the entertainment world. This roll-call included Shabana Azmi, Zahan Kapoor and corporate czarinas like Namita Thapar and Avarna Jain. But the Conclave also showcased a robot-making innovator, a woman entrepreneur who braved the Maoist threat, and a museum man from Bihar. In times that defy even Moore's Law on the pace of change, historian William Dalrymple took us to an ancient world where India ruled the world of ideas, and world chess champion D. Gukesh, cool as a cucumber at 18, showed why modern India was the king in the old chequered game of thrones. Turn these pages and savour our festival of unique conversations.



(Aroon Purie)